PLSC 113
Introduction to Comparative Politics

Instructor: Robin E. Best
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Office Hours: Tuesdays and Thursdays
1:45-2:45 p.m. and by appointment

Lectures: Tues. & Thurs.
11:45 a.m. – 1:15 p.m.
Lecture Hall 1
Binghamton University
Fall 2026

Course Description

In this course, we will explore the rich diversity of political life that exists around the globe by examining both how and why governments and politics differ from country to country. In order to give students the tools needed to understand and evaluate arguments about the political world, we will begin with a brief introduction to some of the methods used by political scientists. We will then examine cross-national differences in political regimes, dictatorships, democracies, political institutions, voting systems, political parties, and political behavior. Some of the questions we will address are as follows. Under what conditions are transitions to democracy most likely to succeed? What makes some states more stable than others? Why do some countries have many political parties while others have few? Why does turnout at elections vary so greatly across countries?

Although the course is organized topically, we will use specific countries as examples of the concepts discussed in class. At the end of the course students should have developed: (1) the ability to evaluate and analyze arguments that apply to politics; (2) a general knowledge of the variety of political systems that exist around the world; and (3) more specific knowledge about politics in some countries.

Course Requirements

This course is a 4-credit course, which means that in addition to the scheduled lectures/discussions, students are expected to do at least 9.5 hours of course-related work each week during the semester. This includes things like: completing assigned readings, participating in discussion sessions, studying for tests and examinations, preparing written assignments, and other tasks that must be completed to earn credit in the course.

Lectures: Students are expected to attend all lectures having completed the assigned readings. There will be material in the lectures that is not in the textbook, and vice versa, so it is imperative that students both attend the lectures and complete the assigned readings.

Discussion Sections: Each student is scheduled to participate in a weekly discussion section. Discussion sections are intended to be a more interactive learning environment. Students are expected to be active participants in all discussion sessions. Attendance and participation in discussion sections will constitute 19% of the course grade. Students may miss ***one*** discussion section without receiving a grade deduction. Students are required to abide by all rules and requirements set by their Teaching Assistant regarding the discussion sections. Discussion sections will also help prepare students for course exams, by reviewing and explaining the material covered in lectures.

Exams: There will be three, non-cumulative exams that consist of multiple choice and short answer questions. Each exam will constitute 27% of the course grade. The first two exam dates are listed in the course schedule. The last exam will be held during the scheduled final-exam time for this course. Students are responsible for making sure they are able to be present on the day of an exam. Make-up exams will be given only in the case of an emergency situation, such as an injury or severe illness. It is up to the instructor to decide what constitutes an emergency situation. If you have a known conflict with a scheduled exam, please notify the instructor ahead of time.

Grading Scale: A (93-100), A- (90-92), B+ (87-89), B (83-86), B- (80-82), C+ (77-79), C (73-76), C- (70-72), D (60-69), F(0-59).

Readings

The following textbook is required for the course. I would recommend purchasing a hard copy, but e-versions are available as well.

- Clark, William Roberts, Matt Golder and Sona Nadenichek Golder. 2024. *Principles of Comparative Politics, 4th Edition.* Washington, D.C.: CQ Press.

Learning Objectives

As one of the introductory lecture courses in Political Science, this course is intended to contribution to Political Science majors' achievement of the following objectives:

1) Awareness of the main overall elements of the discipline, incorporating knowledge of three of the four principal subfields of political science (American Politics, International Relationship, Comparative Politics, Political Theory).

2) Basic knowledge of theories and methods of interpreting information for political science purposes.

3) The ability to engage in critical thinking and critical discourse.

Completion of this course will also satisfy the following learning outcomes for general education requirements.

- G requirement – Global Interdependencies: Students will demonstrate knowledge of how two or more distinctive world regions have influenced and interacted with one another and how such interactions have been informed by their respective cultures or civilizations.

- N requirement – Social Sciences: Students will demonstrate (1) knowledge of major concepts, models, and issues (and their interrelationships) in political science, and (2) an understanding of the methods used by social scientists to explore social phenomena, including, when appropriate to the discipline, observation, hypothesis development, measurement and data collection, experimentation, evaluation of evidence, and analysis by mathematics or other interpretive frameworks.

Other Requirements

Brightspace. We will be using the Brightspace website for the course to post announcements, grades, and other course materials. It is your responsibility to make sure you have access to the Brightspace course website.

AI Policy. Students should not use any type of artificial intelligence to complete assignments for the course, unless explicitly instructed to do so by the professor. Failure to abide by this rule will be treated as an academic honesty violation.

Student Conduct. Students are expected to behave in a respectful manner and to refrain from disruptive behavior such as talking, whispering, or making offensive remarks. Any student engaging in inappropriate or disruptive behavior may be asked to leave the classroom. Students are expected to arrive on time for lectures and discussion sections. Students who arrive late to class may be asked to leave the classroom.

Electronics Policy

Cell phones: Cell phone use is not allowed under any circumstances. Cell phones must be turned off and stored so that they are not visible. Any student caught talking on the phone or texting will be asked to leave the classroom. If your phone rings in class you will be given a warning. If it happens again you will be asked to leave the classroom.

Laptops: ***Laptop use is strongly discouraged in the classroom***. Laptops and other electronic devices often distract your attention from the class and prevent you from being fully engaged. See, for example, http://www.npr.org/2016/04/17/474525392/attention-students-put-your-laptops-away. If you must use your laptop, it may be used for note-taking purposes only. If we find you using your laptop for other purposes (social media, email, etc.) you will be asked to put it away.

Other Devices: No other electronic devices are to be used in the classroom, and lectures may not be recorded. Exceptions to all of these policies will be made for accommodations recommended by the SSD.

Exceptions to this policy will be made for students with registered disabilities. Please note that these rules apply only to the lectures. Your TA will have their own electronics policy for the discussion section.

Grade Appeals. If you wish to appeal a grade you have received, you must submit a one-page statement to your instructor and TA at least 24 hours after receiving the grade. The statement must clearly and thoroughly explain the reasons why your work deserves a higher grade. Your assignment will then be re-graded, taking your statement into consideration. **The revised grade may be higher, lower, or the same as the initial grade**.

Disability-Related Equal Access Accommodations. Students wishing to request academic accommodations to insure their equitable access and participation in this course should notify the instructor by the second week of class. Authorizations from Services for Students with Disabilities (SSD) are generally required. Please contact SSD at (607)777-2686 to schedule an appointment with the Director or Learning Disabilities Specialist. Their website (www.binghamton.edu/ssd) includes information regarding their Disability Documentation Guidelines. The office is located in UU-119.

Academic Honesty. Students should review university guidelines regarding academic honesty and ensure that the work they complete for this course is theirs and theirs alone. Cases of academic dishonesty will be taken very seriously and may result in a failing grade for the course in addition to any penalty imposed by the university. If you have any doubt about what constitutes plagiarism or a violation of academic honesty, please consult the university code and/or contact the instructor.
Information on plagiarism can be found at
http://www2.binghamton.edu/watson/about/academic-honesty.html.
Tutorials on academic honesty can be found at
http://library.binghamton.edu/research/tutorials/WebTutorials/web/index.html.

Resources for Students in Distress. If you are experiencing undue personal or academic stress at any time during the semester or need to talk with someone about a personal problem or situation, I encourage you to seek support as soon as possible. Significant stress, mood changes, excessive worry, or problems with eating and/or sleeping can interfere with optimal academic performance. The source of symptoms might be related to your course work; if so, I invite you to speak with me (or your other professors) directly. However, problems with relationships, family worries, loss, or a personal struggle or crisis can also contribute to decreased academic performance, and may require additional professional support. Binghamton University provides a variety of support resources: the Dean of Students Office and University Counseling Center offer coaching on ways to reduce the impact to your grades. Numbers for these and other available resources are provided below.

1. Dean of Students Office: 607-777-2804
2. Decker Student Health Services Center: 607-777-2221
3. University Police: On campus emergency, 911
4. University Counseling Center: 607-777-2772

5. Interpersonal Violence Prevention: 607-777-3062
6. Harpur Advising: 607-777-6305
7. Office of International Student & Scholar Services: 607-777-2510

Schedule

Week 1: Aug. 18 & 20 **The Scientific Study of Politics I**
*No discussion sections this week

Readings: Clark, Golder, and Golder. Chapter 1

Week 2: Aug. 25 & 27 **The Scientific Study of Politics II**

Readings: Clark, Golder, and Golder. Chapter 2

Week 3: Sept. 1 & 3 **The Modern Nation-State**

Readings: Clark, Golder, and Golder. Chapter 3

Week 4: Sept. 8 **Monday classes meet (not Tuesday classes)**
Sept. 10 **The Modern Nation-State**

Readings: Clark, Golder, and Golder. Chapter 4

Week 5: Sept. 15 **Review**
Sept. 17 **Exam I**

Week 6: Sept. 22 & 24 **Measuring Democracy I**

Readings: Clark, Golder, and Golder. Chapter 5

Week 7: Sept. 29 & Oct. 1 **Determinants of Democracy I**

Readings: Clark, Golder, and Golder. Chapters 6 & 7

Week 8: Oct. 6 & 8 **Determinants of Democracy II**

Readings: Clark, Golder, and Golder. Chapter 8

Week 9: Oct. 13 & 15 **No Classes – Fall Break**

Week 10: Oct. 20 & 22 **Dictatorships**

Readings: Clark, Golder, and Golder. Chapter 9

Week 11: Oct. 27 **Review**
Oct. 29 **Exam 2**

Week 12: Nov. 3 & 5 **Group Decision-Making**

Readings: Clark, Golder, and Golder, Chapter 10

Week 13: Nov. 11 & 13 **Party Systems & Electoral Systems**

Readings: Clark, Golder, and Golder. Chapters 12 & 13

Week 14: Nov. 17 & 19 **Presidents and Parliaments**

Readings: Clark, Golder, and Golder. Chapter 11

Week 15: Nov. 24 **No Class – Friday Classes Meet**
Nov. 26 **No Class – Thanksgiving break**

Week 16: Dec. 1 & 3 **The Consequences of Democracy/Dictatorship**

Readings: Clark, Golder, and Golder. Chapters 14 & 15

Week 17: Dec. 8th **Review**

Exam #3 TBD